I was on the test stand when pressure pick-ups (transducers) were being mounted on the head-end of the rocket. Thankaiyan, one of our best fitters, was at work. Consistent good work and laurels can make one overconfident, and Thankaiyan was no exception to this rule. He used a normal spanner to tighten the screw, against the norm that specifies use of a torque wrench that allows to preset and limit the extent of tightening. I had told him on earlier occasions not to rely always on spanners, but Thankaiyan felt his experience was superior to the precision of the torque wrench.

As Thankaiyan turned the spanner a wee bit more than necessary, the screw gave way, leaving a hole at the head-end of the rocket. The other side of the hole was exposed to the propellant. This meant the test could not be conducted.

The way out was to drill a hole to pluck out the broken part of the screw and seal the part. This means that the engine has to be tested without a transducer, and hence the pressure of the engine cannot be gauged during the test. After all, it was only a static test and not a flight test. But the danger of this option was not in the performance of the engine during the test, but the possibility of an explosion during the drilling which produces sparks. If a spark goes through the hole and if, by another stroke of bad luck, it gets in touch with the propellant, the engine and the test facility would be pulverised, not to speak of what would happen to the people around.

Call it foolhardiness of age or the overenthusiasm of a scientist to impress the chairman, I decided to take the risk. Later I realised the irony. I was fixing a problem that resulted from a worker's overconfidence with a solution that stemmed from my overconfidence. In all fairness, Thankaiyan's was a mishap; mine an invitation to disaster.

For now, however, it was payback time for Thankaiyan.

'You are going to drill out the screw and seal the part,' I told him.

Thankaiyan nodded.

'You know the consequences, don't you?'

He nodded again.